A SHORT TALK · ABOUT 4 MINUTES

Ramen's fat problem

What is really in the bowl, and how to keep eating it smarter.

noodles · broth · tare · oil · toppings

SPEAKER NOTES · SLIDE 1

Hi everyone. Today I want to talk about one of my favorite foods, ramen, and the part nobody puts on the menu: how much fat is in the bowl.

WHY THIS MATTERS

Ramen is eaten billions of times every year

~120 bn

instant noodle servings eaten worldwide in a year

2–3 min

to make a pack, which is why it is a weeknight default

1 bowl

can carry most of a day's fat, depending on the style

Instant-noodle volume: World Instant Noodles Association annual demand estimates (roughly 120 billion servings in 2023).

SPEAKER NOTES · SLIDE 2

Ramen is eaten billions of times every year. Instant noodles alone are about 120 billion servings worldwide. So small changes to one bowl add up to a lot of fat.

EXHIBIT A · ONE PACK OF INSTANT RAMEN

A single pack, before any toppings

~14 g
total fat

~6.5 g
saturated fat, about a third of the 20 g daily value

~380 kcal
for a block most people eat in one sitting

Share of the 78 g daily fat value — 18%



Typical values for an 85 g fried-noodle pack; brands vary. Daily values: FDA, 78 g fat and 20 g saturated fat on a 2,000 kcal diet.

SPEAKER NOTES · SLIDE 3

Let's start with the cheapest version. A typical pack of instant ramen has around 14 grams of fat and 6 to 7 grams of saturated fat. That is about a fifth of your daily fat before you add anything.

Instant noodles are fried in palm oil

- Fresh noodles are steamed, then **flash fried** to drive out water. That is what makes the block shelf-stable.
- The frying oil soaks in: fried blocks are often **around 20% fat by weight**.
- The usual oil is **palm oil**, which is roughly half saturated fat.

~50%

of palm oil's fat is saturated, versus roughly 15% for canola oil.

Non-fried (air-dried) instant noodles exist and usually carry far less fat; check the label.

SPEAKER NOTES · SLIDE 4

Why is a dry block of noodles so fatty? Instant noodles are flash fried in palm oil. Frying is how they dry out so fast and cook in three minutes. Palm oil is about half saturated fat.

EXHIBIT B · A RESTAURANT TONKOTSU BOWL

The shop bowl can be most of a day's fat

40–60 g
fat, a common estimate for a full tonkotsu bowl

800+ kcal
often well over, with extra noodles (kaedama)

12+ hrs
of hard boiling that emulsifies bone fat into the broth

Share of the 78 g daily fat value (at 55 g) 71%



Restaurants rarely publish nutrition; figures are estimates and vary widely by shop, portion, and toppings.

SPEAKER NOTES · SLIDE 5

Restaurant ramen is a different story. A rich tonkotsu bowl, with that creamy pork-bone broth and slices of pork belly, is often estimated at 40 to 60 grams of fat. That can be most of a day in one meal.

ANATOMY OF A BOWL

Where the fat hides

The broth

Pork bones boiled hard turn milky because fat and collagen emulsify into the soup.

Chashu

Braised pork belly, often two or three slices, is one of the fattiest cuts.

Aroma oil

A spoon of lard, chicken fat, black garlic oil (mayu) or chili oil floats on top.

Back fat

Seabura, pork back fat shaken over some styles, adds richness by the spoonful.

Butter

A pat on Sapporo-style miso butter corn ramen melts straight in.

Fried extras

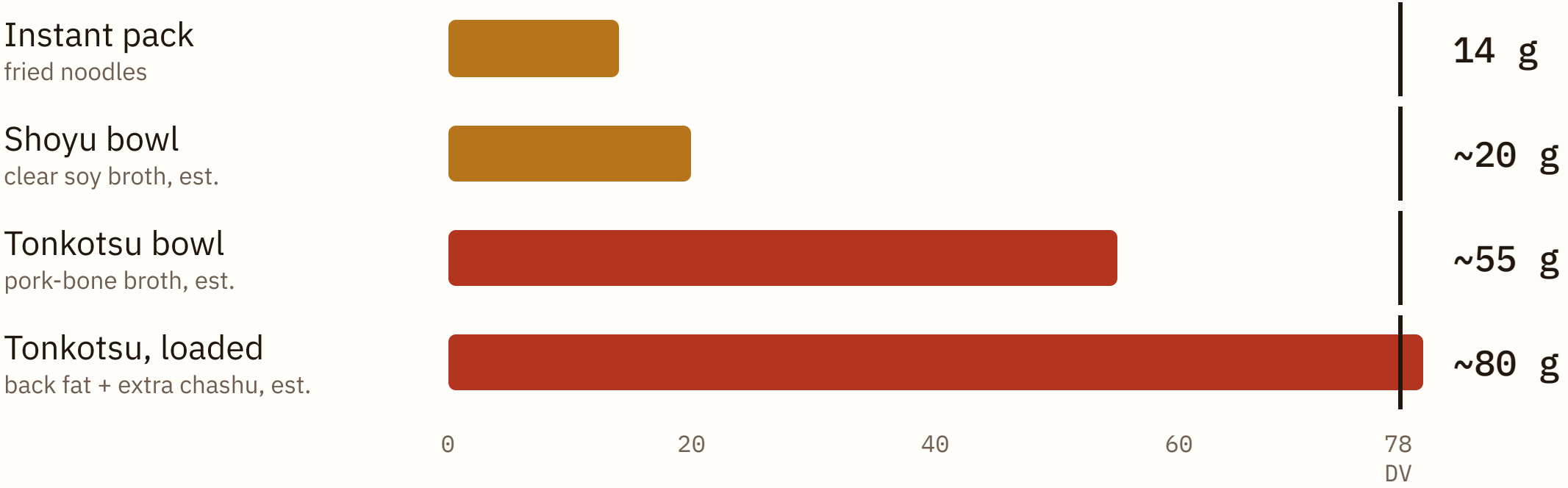
Karaage, fried garlic and tempura bits pile on more oil.

SPEAKER NOTES · SLIDE 6

So where does it all come from? Tonkotsu broth and pork belly carry most of the fat. Then there is aroma oil on top, back fat some shops sprinkle in, butter in miso ramen, and fried toppings.

FAT PER SERVING, GRAMS

On one scale against the daily value



Scale 0–80 g. Restaurant values are illustrative estimates, not lab measurements.

SPEAKER NOTES · SLIDE 7

Here is the comparison on one scale. The black line is the 78 gram daily value. Instant is under a fifth of it. A lighter shoyu bowl is around a quarter. A rich tonkotsu bowl gets most of the way there, and adding back fat and extra pork can push past it.

THE HEALTH ANGLE

Saturated fat raises LDL cholesterol

- Saturated fat raises **LDL cholesterol**, a major risk factor for heart disease.
- The American Heart Association suggests under **6% of calories** from saturated fat, about **13 g a day** on 2,000 kcal.
- A 2014 study of Korean adults linked eating instant noodles **2+ times a week** to higher odds of metabolic syndrome in women.

13 g

AHA saturated-fat target for a whole day. A rich tonkotsu bowl can reach it alone.

AHA dietary guidance on saturated fat; Shin et al., Journal of Nutrition, 2014. Associations, not proof of cause.

Why care? Saturated fat raises LDL cholesterol, the kind linked to heart disease. The American Heart Association suggests keeping saturated fat to about 13 grams a day. One rich bowl can cover that by itself. And a 2014 Korean study found women who ate instant noodles twice a week or more had higher odds of metabolic syndrome.

AND IT BRINGS SALT ALONG

Most of the fat and salt sits in the soup

1,500–2,000 mg
sodium in a typical bowl or pack with its full seasoning

2,300 mg
FDA daily value for sodium

Soup
is where the seasoning, oil and rendered fat end up

Share of the 2,300 mg sodium daily value (at 1,750 mg) 76%



Typical label ranges for instant packs; restaurant bowls are often similar or higher.

And fat travels with salt. Most bowls carry somewhere around 1,500 to 2,000 milligrams of sodium, close to the whole daily value. Most of both sits in the soup.

FIXES

Leave the soup and order shoyu or shio

At the shop

- Order **shoyu or shio**, clear broths, instead of tonkotsu.
- **Leave most of the soup**. Eat the noodles and toppings.
- Say no to **back fat** and the extra oil spoon.
- Swap chashu for **chicken, egg or tofu**; add bean sprouts and greens.

At home

- Buy **non-fried** (air-dried) noodles.
- Use **half the seasoning packet** and skip the oil sachet.
- Cook the noodles, **drain the water**, then add fresh hot water or stock.
- Bulk it up with **spinach, cabbage, an egg**.

SPEAKER NOTES · SLIDE 10

The good news: you don't have to quit. At a ramen shop, leave the soup and order shoyu or shio instead of tonkotsu. Skip the back fat, swap pork belly for chicken or egg, and add vegetables.

THE ASK

Keep the bowl.
Try one swap this week.

Leave half the soup, pick a clear broth, or use half the packet.

Thank you.

SPEAKER NOTES · SLIDE 11

So keep the bowl. My ask is small: try one swap this week. Leave half the soup, or pick shoyu, or use half the packet. Your taste buds will adjust faster than you think. Thank you.